## < ADITI ASHOK, 26

***Golf***

**The grand stage of the Olympics brings the best out of Aditi Ashok. In Rio 2016, as the youngest in the field, the then 18-year-old was 41st among the world's best golfers. Five years later in Tokyo, ranked 200 in the world, Aditi had the cricket-crazy nation glued to their screens in the early hours to follow the strokes, swings and putts on the greens as she dominated the first three rounds, only to relinquish her lead on the final day. She'd miss the podium by one birdie. Could this third time be lucky? Yet, Paris will be different. Unlike other editions where she was the underdog, Aditi comes in ranked higher (#60) and with valuable LPGA experience. "I'm looking forward to that week, hopefully I can do better than I did in Tokyo," Aditi told INDIA TODAY magazine last year. A position better and she'll make history—the first Indian golfer to win a medal. ■**




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## ROHAN BOPANNA, 44 ^
## SRIRAM BALAJI, 34 v

***Tennis*** *Men's Doubles*

If results in the past few months are anything to go by, clay is not Rohan Bopanna's surface of choice. The rallies are long and Bopanna, with worn-out cartilages in both knees, cannot chase down balls like before. But that proved no deterrent when early this year, at the ripe old sporting age of 43, he won his first men's doubles Grand Slam title, winning the Australian Open with partner Matthew Ebden. For what's likely to be his swan song at the Olympics, the World No. 4 in doubles has chosen Sriram Balaji (ranked 64) as his partner. The big servers will be hoping to put on a stellar show in the iconic stade Roland Garros, home to the French Open. Bopanna is the epitome of the never-say-die mentality. Could he join Leander Paes (bronze medallist at the 1996 Atlanta Games) and crown his career with an Olympic medal? Bopanna is surely in with a chance, for fortune favours the brave in tennis results at the Olympics. ■



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